

**Dearly Beloved, You've Hurt Me: A Study on Gendered Social Dynamics and
Interpersonal Forgiveness and Leniency**

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Abstract

This study investigates the influence of *HarmLevel* (Low vs. High Offense), *RelationshipStatus* (Best Friend, Boyfriend, Girlfriend), *ParticipantGender*, and *OffenderGender* on relational outcome probabilities such as *RelationshipDamage*, *LongTermForgiveness*, and *RelationshipEnd*. This study conducted a factorial analysis of variance on 194 data points (94 participants), collected mostly from students attending the 5cs. Analysis revealed that while harm level (low vs. high) had the strongest main effect, its impact was highly dependent on the relationship's context and gender dynamics. Significant *HarmLevel* * *RelationshipStatus* interactions were found for both *RelationshipDamage* ($p = 0.25$) and *RelationshipEnd* ($p = 0.36$). Simple effects tests showed that best friend relationships were resilient, showing no significant difference between Low and High Harm offense for both male and female post-situation reactions. Conversely, romantic relationships demonstrated strong gender sensitivity. These findings highlight that the consequences of an offense are never universal; While a high harm offense is generally more damaging, the exact way individuals react and whether they choose to end the relationship is governed by a complex set of standards related to relationship type and inherent gender differences.

Introduction

Human relationships are the fundamental building blocks of both psychological well-being and social structure. Yet a relationship's stability is heavily reliant on a fragile idea called trust. When this foundation of trust is fractured, the relationship falters, forcing a reevaluation of the connection's worth. In this moment, the act of forgiveness stands as the ultimate judge, determining whether or not a broken relationship can be repaired.

Forgiveness in psychology is acknowledged as an internal shift in motivation towards the one who has committed wrongdoing against you (APA Dictionary of Psychology). According to the model established by McCullough et al.(1997), forgiving involves reducing the two negative reactions of avoidance and revenge, and increasing feelings of goodwill towards that individual. This was foundational in the study of forgiveness, and moved the concept beyond simple reconciliation. As Sengupta et al. (2025) further prove in their recent study, forgiveness is beyond reconciliation, yielding psychological benefits such as enhanced well-being, even if the victim makes the choice not to reconcile. Therefore, while reconciliation is re-engagement that requires both parties to rebuild a relationship, forgiveness is solely the victim's own journey away from negativity.

When it comes to forgiveness, a large amount of research has been conducted on an individual's natural tendency to forgive. Certain personality traits and cognitive orientations have been consistently proven to predict likelihood of forgiveness. For example, Skalski-Bednarz et al. (2024) used a two-wave longitudinal study to explore the Big Five personality traits as predictors of forgiveness. Their model found that agreeableness predicted decisional forgiveness (the thoughts of forgiving) while extraversion and emotional stability predicted emotional forgiveness (the reduction of negative emotions towards offender). Expanding on the role of dispositional capacity, Tsang and Stanford (2007) studied forgiveness in difficult relational circumstances and found that victims with higher levels of empathy and

religiousness were more likely to report having forgiven their partner. These findings suggest that the propensity to forgive is rooted in an individual's psychological characteristics.

However, a meta-analytic synthesis by Fehr et al. (2010) identified that dispositional capacity only predicts a part of the whole story. Their findings confirmed that while trait factors such as empathy and humility are important predictors, situational factors ultimately accounted for a greater portion of the variance in forgiveness decisions. Some variables that had notable effects were the offender's intent, presence of a meaningful apology, and the victim's emotional experience (empathy, anger, etc). This study emphasizes how individual traits and external factors interact, highlighting the greater significance of the situational factors when it comes to forgiving.

Given that situational circumstances heavily influence one's willingness to forgive, it is natural to question the effect of the quality of relationship on willingness to forgive. Fincham et al. (2002), focusing on married couples, found that a high-quality relationship and empathy for the partner made overall forgiveness more likely. This may seem obvious, but it was shown that forgiveness was significantly hindered when the hurt party blamed internal attributions for the offense. This concept of relational context is further explored by Zahorcova and Krahucova (2023). Their study combined large scale surveys with detailed interviews, providing a deeper look into forgiveness in romantic relationships. Like previous studies, they confirmed that quantitative variables such as relationships satisfaction and empathy were significant promoters of forgiveness. More importantly, however, they found that the victim's assessment of the severity and nature of the offense plays a crucial role in determining the possibility for forgiveness.

The dynamic between the victim and the perpetrator is also critical, as perception of different words or actions can differ significantly across parties. Kearns and Fincham (2005) compared the viewpoints of both parties in romantic relationships after a conflict. It was found that often, the perpetrator believes they have been forgiven more quickly/ completely than the

victim actually feels. This misalignment in belief can obstruct true reconciliation, proving the importance of an internal forgiveness process before a relationship recovers.

While interpersonal dynamics shape how forgiveness unfolds between individuals, demographic factors such as gender may further influence how forgiveness is perceived and expressed. A meta-analytic review conducted by Miller et al. (2008) found that overall differences between males and females in the tendency to forgive are generally minimal. However they recommended that future research should explore specific social and relationship contexts where gender might play a larger role. To address this, Aisyah and Agung (2020) studied adolescent friendships and found that higher forgiveness levels were associated with greater friendship intimacy, even after the conflict occurred. There was also a difference in gendered responses, where friendship intimacy was more strongly linked for males than females, although both had a positive relationship. Similarly, Singh et al. (2025) explored the experiences of unforgiveness, and aimed to explore the differences in how males and females experience and express being unforgiving. They found that men viewed unforgiveness as a tool for offender reform, whereas women saw it as a means of protection.

Building on these foundations, this study is designed to explore how gender and relationship type shape forgiveness responses to situations with varying severity. Previous research has shown that forgiveness is associated differently with friendship intimacy for males and females, leaving an open question about the comparative dynamics in romantic vs platonic contexts. Additionally, Singh (2025) highlights distinct gendered motivations for unforgiveness, suggesting that men and women may also navigate forgiveness for different relational purposes. Given these insights, the current study addresses two main hypotheses. The first being that females will be more forgiving towards their friends and less forgiving towards their romantic partners (males show the opposite pattern). The second hypothesis is that individuals will be less forgiving towards their romantic partners for severe offenses in comparison to a friend, while the differences between relationship types will be minimal when the harm is low.

Method

Participants

The participant population for this study consists mostly of undergraduate students at the 5cs, along with a small selection of undergraduate students from universities across the US and recent post-graduate individuals. Participants of the study were collected through two platforms, including distribution of the survey link via relevant social media channels (to capture a broad sample), and leveraging CMC Sona Systems for structured subject pool access. Eligibility is conditional upon providing explicit informed consent prior to the commencement of the study, and a total of 112 individuals participated in this study. Of the 112 participants, 15 individuals were omitted from the analysis due to late submissions and invalid answers to the survey.

Procedure

This study was conducted remotely using the Qualtrics survey platform. Upon beginning the survey, participants will first encounter a detailed informed consent form that shows transparency on research goals, time commitment, and confidentiality on all responses. Progression into the study will only be allowed after consent is given through a yes or no question. Following their consent, participants will go through a brief demographic section with questions about age and gender identification.

The content of the study uses a $2 \times 2 \times 3 \times 2$ factorial design to examine the effect of two independent variables (Level of Harm and Relationship type) on participants' forgiveness measures. To optimize participant focus and avoid repetition, the study was designed to have each participant exposed to only two of the 12 written scenarios: one randomly selected Low Harm scenario, and one randomly selected high harm scenario. The relationship type for each of these two presented scenarios are independently randomized. Prior to each scenario, participants are provided with instructions to imagine themselves in the situation as vividly as

possible, encouraging deep immersion into the emotional and cognitive responses to each scenario.

During analysis, each participant was divided into two separate data points based on the low vs high harm scenario, totaling 194 data points to analyze.

Materials

The stimuli materials consist of a survey questionnaire, with a total of twelve distinct written scenarios. These scenarios were constructed to be parallel across experimental conditions. All Low Harm scenarios are textually identical, with an exception of the perpetrator's gender and corresponding pronouns. The same textual standardization applies to all High Harm scenarios. The scenarios fall into two categories: Low Harm, describing a partner or friend publicly ridiculing the participant's passion project on social media, leading to embarrassment, undermined confidence, and public humiliation. Conversely, the high harm scenario depicts a far more serious offense, where the partner/friend secretly breaches a new shared apartment lease after the participant has already paid their half of a large security deposit, resulting in financial loss and housing instability. Across both levels of harm, the perpetrator's identity is manipulated to represent a girlfriend, boyfriend, or best friend. All other textual material within each level of harm is kept standardized.

Following each of these two scenarios, participants are presented with a set of 8 questions designed to capture the dependent variables related to forgiveness and conflict response. These questions test the participant's immediate response, perceived relational damage, willingness to forgive (immediate and delayed), conflict resolution strategy, perceived responsibility, and relationship termination intent. The following questions were used: Immediately following the incident, how intensely would you feel hurt or angry by the situation? (percentage response scale), How damaging do you think this instance will be to the relationship described? (10-point Likert Scale: 1 = No damage at all, 10 = Irreparable damage), I would be willing to fully forgive them for this action immediately in the moment. (10-point

Likert Scale: 1 = Strongly Disagree, 10 = Strongly Agree), I would be willing to fully forgive them for this action after a year passes. (10-point Likert Scale: 1 = Strongly Disagree, 10 = Strongly Agree), My first reaction would be to withdraw from the situation rather than looking to discuss the issue with them. (10-point Likert Scale: 1 = No. They should approach me first. 10 = Yeah, I will resolve the issue with them right now.), How much responsibility do I feel for creating this conflict? (percentage response scale), How much responsibility do I have for resolving this conflict? (percentage response scale), I would end my relationship with this person after the scenario. (yes/ no)

Results

Overall

A multivariate test of between-subject effects showed that the four independent variables (Participant Gender, Offender Gender, Relationship Type, and Harm Level) significantly explains the variation in the following variables: Immediate Level of Hurt ($F = 2.866, p = .001$), Damage to the Relationship ($F = 2.381, p = .007$), Long Term Forgiveness ($F = 2.244, p = .012$), and the End of a Relationship ($F = 5.241, p < .001$).

Main Effects

The main effect of harm level proved to be the most significant factor, significantly predicting nearly all outcomes, but most notably for *RelationshipDamage* ($F = 15.970, p < .001$) and the probability of *RelationshipEnd* ($F = 24.104, p < .001$). High harm offenses were generally associated with greater relationship damage and a higher likelihood of the relationship ending as seen by the disparity in means in Figure 3. Harm level also had significant main effects on almost all other dependent variables including *ImmediateHurt*, *ImmediateForgiveness*, *LongTermForgiveness*, *Withdrawal*, and *ConflictCreationResponsibility*.

The main effect of Relationship Status was not significant for the outcomes of Relationship Damage ($F = 1.876, p = .156$) or Relationship End probability ($F = 1.348, p = .263$).

Participant Gender had a significant main effect on Relationship End probability ($F = 5.937, p = .003$), and a marginally significant effect on Withdrawal ($F = 2.972, p = .054$).

Interaction Effects

Analysis revealed significant two-way interactions between HarmLevel and Relationship Type for both Relationship Damage ($F = 3.760, p = .025$), and Relationship End probability ($F = 3.384, p = .036$). Simple effects tests revealed that harm level was a significant predictor of damage only within romantic relationships, with no significant statistical difference between levels of relationship damage reported for low and high levels of harm in the best friend condition. When looking at romantic relationships and the probability of a relationship to end, a gender-sensitive pattern is clearly seen. When the offender is depicted as a boyfriend, sensitivity to harm level is universal. All participants (both male and female) report significantly greater levels of relationship damage in the high harm condition compared to the low harm conditions. However when the offender is a girlfriend, the effect of harm level is conditional on the participant's gender. Males will report significantly more damage in the high harm condition ($M_{\text{diff}} = 1.641, p = .020$) when the offender is a girlfriend, but the difference in reported damage is not statistically significant for female participants ($p = 0.263$) in the same condition.

Discussion

Grounded in the theoretical frameworks of social exchange and relational maintenance by Rusbult (1980) as well as the research on gendered differences in emotional processing by Rudolph (2002), this study aimed to address two key research questions. Specifically, the research explored 1. how willingness to forgive an offender changes based on the relationship type across varying low and high harm scenarios, and 2. Whether significant differences in leniency exist between male and female participants when evaluating the offensive scenarios,

considering the perpetrator's gender as well. Two primary hypotheses were formed to guide the investigation.

1. All Participants will be less willing to forgive a best friend than a romantic partner in the high harm scenario.
2. Female participants will show less leniency compared to male participants when evaluating the situation, especially in the high harm scenario.

Relationship Type

The analysis of 194 data points showed surprising results, disproving the first hypothesis and revealing complex gendered differences in leniency. The most significant and obvious finding in this study was the overwhelming main effect of Harm Level, most notably predicting the level of relationship damage ($F = 15.970, p < .001$), and probability of the end of a relationship ($F = 24.104, p < .001$). These results reinforced the conclusions of Fehr et al (2010), confirming that situational variables such as severity of offense are key determinants in forgiveness decisions. However, this effect was significant solely in romantic relationships.

Surprisingly, the best friend relationship condition showed considerable resilience across low and high harm scenarios. This is evidenced by the minimal change in levels of relationship damage reflected by the shallower slope in Figure 1 for the best friend condition, relative to romantic relationships. In other words, when the perpetrator was a best friend, the impact of a high harm offense on the relationship's perceived damage was statistically equivalent to a low harm offense. This finding directly disproves the first hypothesis that states participants would be less willing to forgive a best friend than a romantic partner in the high harm scenario. This result may stem from the fact that individuals hold their significant others to a higher standard of trust and commitment than they do platonic best friends, making a high-harm offense (such as severe financial betrayal) a much deeper breach of trust. On the other hand, it is possible that this result can be attributed to the extended history with a best friend, which acts as a relational buffer, allowing participants to bypass the offense as a situational mistake rather than a

fundamental flaw in character. This explanation is consistent with the findings of Aisyah and Agung (2020), who demonstrated that higher forgiveness levels are associated with greater friendship intimacy, suggesting the strength of the bond transgresses the severity of the offense.

Gendered Differences

In contrast to a more resilient best friend dynamic, romantic relationships exhibited a strong gender-sensitivity to the varying levels of harm severity. When the offender was a boyfriend, the sensitivity to harm level was universal: both male and female participants reported significantly greater damage in the high harm condition. This indicates the consistent high standard of conduct expected from a male romantic partner, which seems applicable and relevant to current societal norms.

However, when the offender was a girlfriend, the effect of harm level was conditional on the participant's gender. Males reported significantly more damage in the high harm condition ($M_{diff} = 1.641$, $p = .020$), yet the difference was not statistically significant for female participants ($p = 0.263$) in the same condition. This result suggests that female participants were more lenient toward a female offender. This partially contradicts the second hypothesis, which predicted that females would show less leniency in general. In reality, females appear to be more lenient towards the female offender, but equally as harsh (if not more so) toward male offenders.

This differential leniency towards a female offender may be a result of in-group bias or heightened empathy among females, leading participants to be more inclined to attribute a girlfriend's offense to situational factors. The nature of the high harm scenario itself may also explain the results. Financial betrayal (high harm scenario) is considered an offense that is culturally less expected from a female romantic partner, causing female participants to attribute the offense to situational factors, minimizing the reported relational damage.

Additionally, female participants, as illustrated in Figure 2, expressed consistently higher levels of intent to end the relationship across both low and high harm conditions compared to their male counterparts. The lack of statistically significant difference in relationship damage

across harm levels, paired with the quick intentions to end the relationship, reinforces Singh et al. (2025)'s argument that women view unforgiveness as a means of protection. This pattern suggests that women may be equally impacted by both low and high harm situations, having developed a protective caution in their relationships to defend themselves from any excess experiences of harm. This would allow them to make swift decisions to terminate their relationships upon experiencing an offensive situation, which is supported by Figure 2.

This study, while producing many insightful results, is subject to several limitations that should be accounted for. Although the study utilizes 194 data points, a large majority of the data was collected from undergraduate students from the 5cs. Because of the limited sample reach, it is hard to generalize these findings to a larger, non-undergraduate population. The study also relied entirely on hypothetical scenarios that participants had to imagine, which would produce inaccurate intensity of emotions compared to a genuine, lived experience. Moving forward, however, this research opens several avenues to deepen the understanding of forgiveness and leniency dynamics in relationships. Future research should aim to replicate this study using a more demographically diverse sample, including participants of varying ages, relationship status, and cultural backgrounds. This would further enhance the study by allowing generalization, and cross-cultural validity. It would also be interesting to dive deeper into the surprising resilience of the close platonic friendships as opposed to romantic relationships.

Ultimately, the results of the study shows that the consequences of a relational offense are heavily impacted by context, gender dynamics, and relationship type, challenging the idea of universal forgiveness responses.

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Appendix

Figure 1:

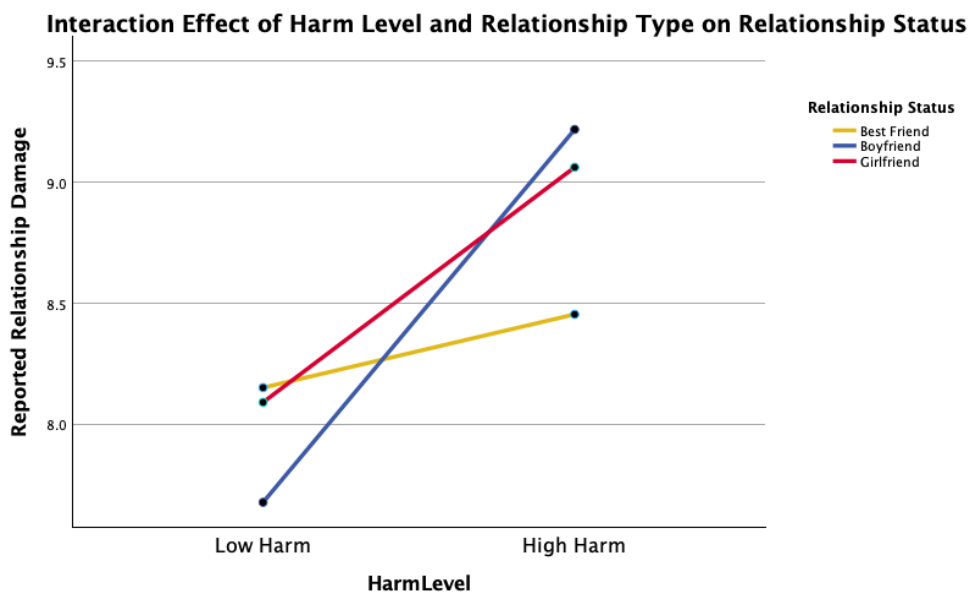


Figure 2:

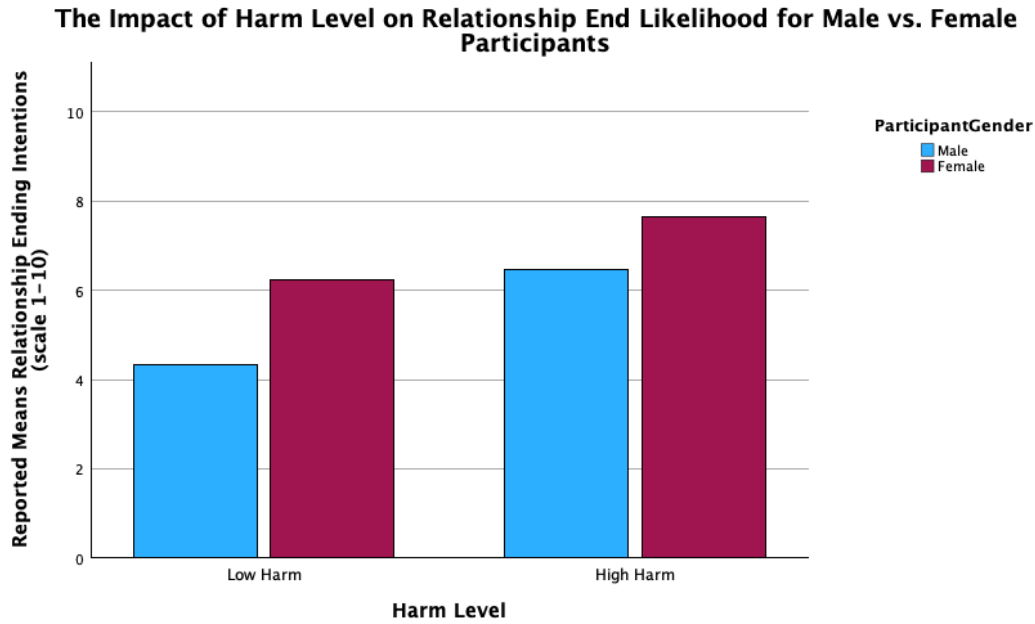


Figure 3:

Table 1

Means of Dependent Variables for Low and High Harm Scenarios

Dependent Variables	Low Harm Condition	High Harm Condition
Immediate Hurt (1-100)	82.67	91.68
Relationship Damage (1-10)	7.98	8.91
Long Term Forgiveness (1-10)	5.91	4.3
Relationship End (1-10)	5.44	7.19

Survey Material

Welcome! Thank you for considering participating in this study about social dynamics and interpersonal forgiveness. This research is expected to take approximately 30 minutes of your time.

All responses are confidential, and the data collected will be stored securely and detached from your name before analysis. Your responses will be aggregated with those of other participants. You may withdraw from the study at any time without penalty by simply closing your browser

window. Please confirm that you have read the information above and understand the terms of your participation.

I have read and understood the information above, and I willingly consent to participate.

I do not consent to participate.

Description: In the following section, you will read one detailed scenario involving a situation where someone close to you has caused harm. Please imagine yourself in the situation as vividly as possible. Once you have read the scenario, you will answer several questions based on your genuine feelings and hypothetical reactions.

Low Harm →

1. Boyfriend:
 - a. You recently started a side business/creative project you are deeply passionate about. Your boyfriend posted a "joke" about it on their large social media platform, implying your work is silly and destined to fail. The post gets dozens of embarrassing comments from his friends, making you feel ridiculed and undermining your confidence in your project.
2. Girlfriend:
 - a. You recently started a side business/creative project you are deeply passionate about. Your girlfriend posted a "joke" about it on their large social media platform, implying your work is silly and destined to fail. The post gets dozens of embarrassing comments from her friends, making you feel ridiculed and undermining your confidence in your project.
3. Best Friend:
 - a. You recently started a side business/creative project you are deeply passionate about. Your best friend posted a "joke" about it on their large social media platform, implying your work is silly and destined to fail. The post gets dozens of embarrassing comments from their friends, making you feel ridiculed and undermining your confidence in your project.

High Harm →

4. Boyfriend:
 - a. You and your boyfriend are planning to move into a new shared space together next month. You have already paid the large security deposit in full. He secretly decides to back out of the lease and move in with a friend instead, leaving you with no way to recover their half of the deposit and unable to afford the new place alone.
5. Girlfriend:
 - a. You and your girlfriend are planning to move into a new shared space together next month. You have already paid the large security deposit in full. She secretly decides to back out of the lease and move in with a friend instead, leaving you

with no way to recover their half of the deposit and unable to afford the new place alone.

6. Best Friend:
 - a. You and your best friend are planning to move into a new shared space together next month. You have already paid the large security deposit in full. They secretly decided to back out of the lease and move in with a friend instead, leaving you with no way to recover their half of the deposit and unable to afford the new place alone.

Questions: (After each presented scenario)

1. Immediately following the incident, how intensely would you feel hurt or angry by the situation?
 - a. 0-100%
2. How damaging do you think this instance will be to the relationship described?
 - a. 10-point Likert Scale: 1 = No damage at all, 10 = Irreparable damage)
3. I would be willing to fully forgive them for this action immediately in the moment.
 - a. 10-point Likert Scale: 1 = Strongly Disagree, 10 = Strongly Agree
4. I would be willing to fully forgive them for this action after a year passes.
 - a. 10-point Likert Scale: 1 = Strongly Disagree, 10 = Strongly Agree)
5. My first reaction would be to withdraw from the situation rather than looking to discuss the issue with them.
 - a. 10-point Likert Scale: 1 = Strongly Disagree/Withdraw (No. they should approach me first.), 10 = Strongly Agree/Seek Resolution (Yeah, I will resolve the issue with them right now.)
6. How much responsibility do I feel for creating this conflict?
 - a. 0-100%
7. How much responsibility do I have for resolving this conflict?
 - a. 0-100%
8. I would end my relationship with this person after the scenario.
 - a. yes/ no

How do you primarily identify your gender?

- a. Female
- b. Male
- c. Non-Binary
- d. other

Thank you for your time and thoughtful responses. Your participation is complete!